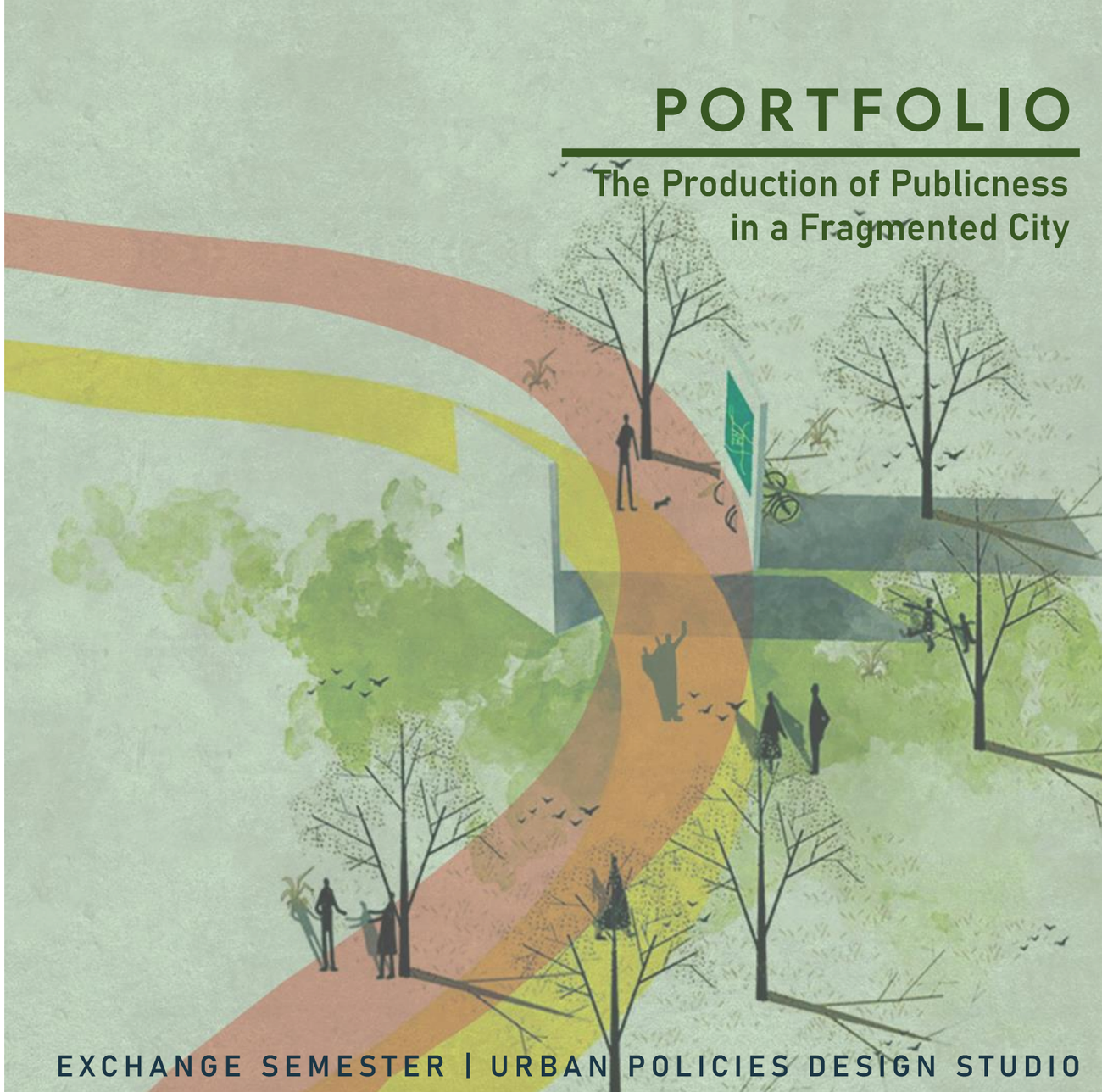
PORTFOLIO

The Production of Publicness in a Fragmented City



EXCHANGE SEMESTER | URBAN POLICIES DESIGN STUDIO

ABOUT THE EXCHANGE SEMESTER

As a part of my fourth semester of the Master of Urban Planning, I was selected to pursue an Exchange Semester at **Politecnico di Milano (PoliMi),** Italy. The exchange offered an immersive experience within the **MSc Urban Planning and Policy Design** programme, exposing me to European planning frameworks, interdisciplinary collaboration, and research-led design methodologies.

Studying in an international academic environment enriched my understanding of contemporary planning practices and strengthened my ability to translate research into strategic and implementable urban interventions.

ABOUT THE STUDIO

The **Urban Policies Design Studio** explored the relationship between spatial design, public policy, and governance in shaping inclusive urban environments. Moving beyond conventional urban design, the studio examined how publicness is produced through the interaction of physical space, institutional frameworks, management strategies, and everyday social practices.

The studio adopted a research-led approach combining spatial analysis, GIS mapping, planning instruments, demographic studies, and fieldwork to understand metropolitan challenges.

POLITECNICO
MILANO 1863

Politecnico di Milano - Scuola di Architettura, Urbanistica e Ingegneria delle costruzioni
Master Degree in Urban Planning and Policy Design A.A. 2025-26

Guided by -

Prof. Antonella Bruzzese, Prof. Gabriele Pasqui

Tutors: Asef Ayatollahi, Alberto Bortolotti, Giulia Oldani, Dafni Riga

INTRODUCTION TO THE PROJECT - PUBLICNESS IN NORTH MILAN

The project focused on Northern Milan, encompassing the municipalities of Cormano, Cusano Milanino, Bresso, Cinisello Balsamo, and Milan's northern districts. Although these municipalities share continuous urban fabric and major regional open spaces, they remain physically and institutionally fragmented.
The project investigated the distinction between **public space** and **publicness**. While public space refers to legally accessible physical environments, publicness is understood as the social condition produced through accessibility, interaction, inclusive design, and everyday use.

Our research examined how fragmented mobility networks, disconnected open spaces, and governance structures influence the production of public life. This understanding ultimately informed the proposal of a continuous East–West Public Corridor, designed to reconnect municipalities and strengthen everyday publicness across the metropolitan landscape.

KEY LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Applied European urban policy frameworks to a real metropolitan context.
- Conducted multi-scalar spatial analysis using GIS, planning instruments, and field observations.
- Developed evidence-based planning strategies linking research with spatial interventions.
- Strengthened collaborative working methods within an international interdisciplinary team.
- Produced implementation frameworks considering phasing, institutional responsibilities, costs, and public benefits.

Exchange Semester | Urban Policies Design Studio

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01 Introduction To The Site

02 Methodology And Research Question

03 Territorial Analysis

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- **7.5** Segment 5: VIA XXV APRILE
- **7.6** Segment 6: GARIBALDI-GRAMSCI

08 How Publicness has Changed?

09 Institutional Framework

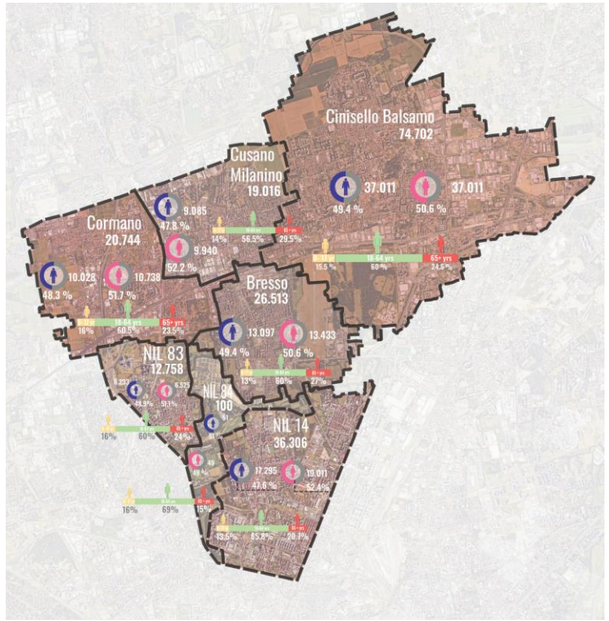
10 Conclusions

11 Key Learnings

Exchange Semester | Urban Policies Design Studio

01 INTRODUCTION TO THE SITE

The study area is located in the northern metropolitan sector of Milan, within the Metropolitan City of Milan (Città Metropolitana di Milano) in the Lombardy region of northern Italy.



Administrative Composition

Municipalities

- Cinisello Balsamo
- Cusano Milanino
- Cormano
- Bresso

Milan Municipal Areas (NIL)

- Bruzzano (NIL 83)
- Parco Nord (NIL 84)
- Niguarda – Ca' Granda (NIL 14)

Population: Over ***302,000*** residents, making it one of the most densely populated suburban systems in northern Milan.

Our Approach and Publicness

OPEN SPACE
Physical voids and scattered pins

PUBLIC SPACE
Isolated Legal containers

PUBLICNESS
The result of social process and inclusive design

INTERVENTIONS
Spatial strategies that enhance connectivity and activity.

Open public spaces are publicly accessible areas of the city that are physically open and collectively usable, designed and managed to support social interaction, recreation, environmental functions, and civic life.

They support daily and shared activities, shape the city's structure, and help improve environmental quality, climate resilience, and public life.

02 METHODOLOGY AND RESEARCH QUESTION

Identifying the main question

Observation of contradiction between map connectivity and on ground fragmentation

Multi Scalar Analysis

The territory was analysed at two complementary scales. The macro and the micro scales to understand everyday public life.

Conceptual Transition

Established publicness as the central analytical lens by transitioning from open space to socially produced public space

Analytical Framework

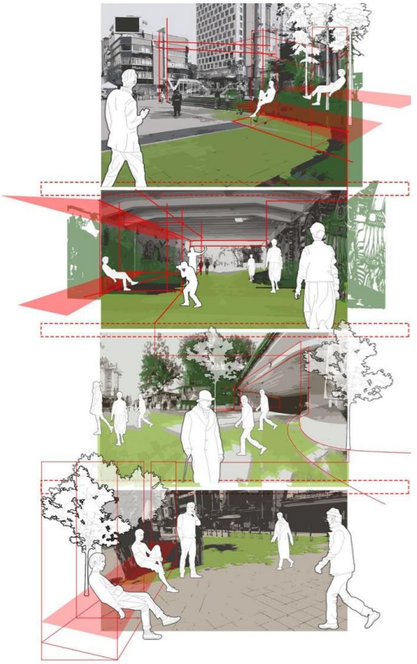
Defined research objectives, indicators, data sources, and analytical methods to systematically investigate the study area.

From Analysis to Strategy

Translated analytical findings into segment-specific spatial strategies and assessing the the potential impact of it.

Implementation Framework

Developed a phased governance and stakeholder framework to ensure long-term delivery and management of publicness.



How does the spatial distribution and quality of public open spaces create publicness and everyday urban life in North Milan?

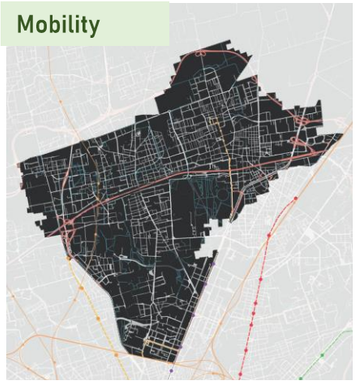
03 TERRITORIAL ANALYSIS

Figure-Ground



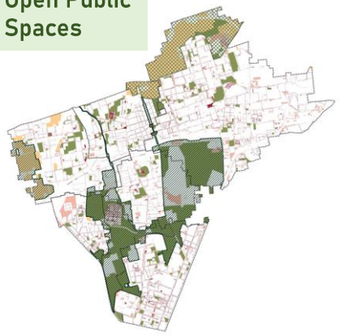
Figure-ground analysis showed a dense yet fragmented urban fabric, where major infrastructure interrupts the continuity between neighbourhoods and public space.

Mobility



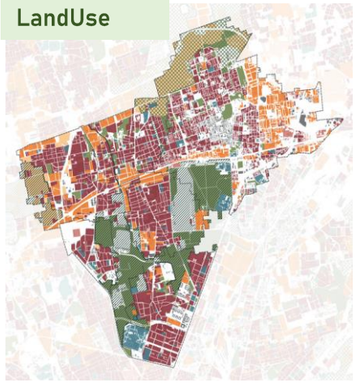
Mobility analysis showed strong regional connectivity but uneven pedestrian accessibility, with major roads acting as physical barriers.

Open Public Spaces



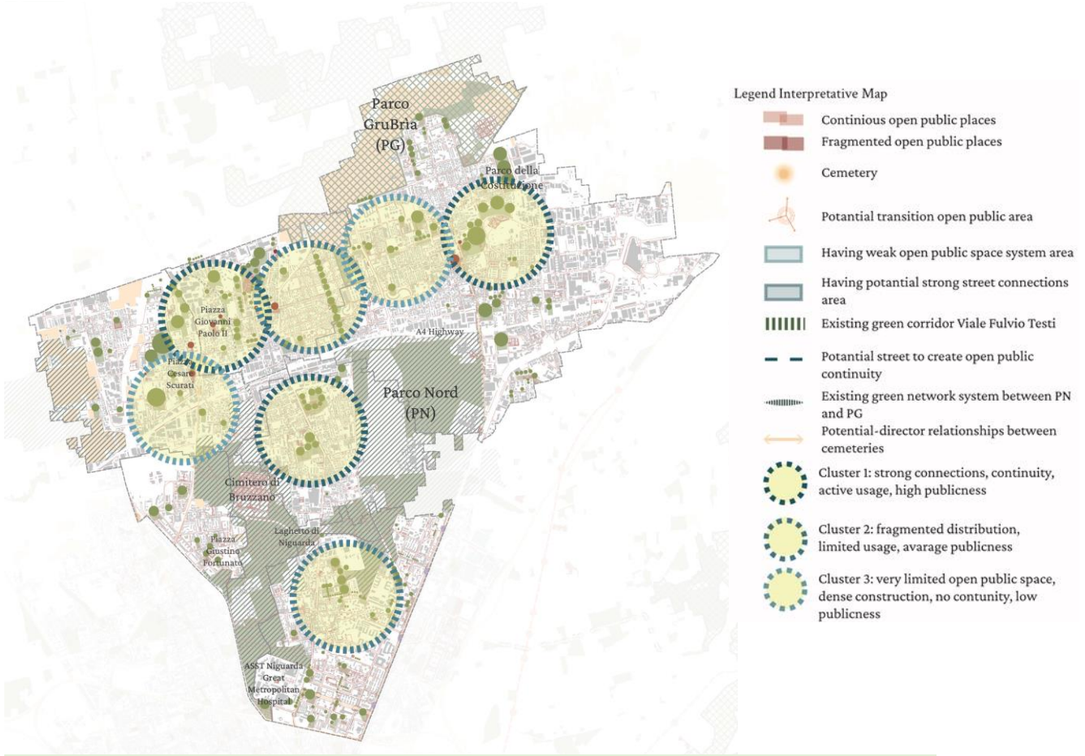
The open public space map identified fragmented open spaces anchored by Parco Nord and Parco GruBria, lacking a continuous public space network.

LandUse



Land use mapping revealed a predominantly residential landscape with green spaces and industrial zones structured along major mobility corridors.

04 INTERPRETATIVE MAP



PROBLEMS VS. OPPORTUNITES

Problems

- Insufficient service access
- Disconnected public open spaces
- Inconsistent Distribution of public spaces
- Uneven NMT system
- Low vitality

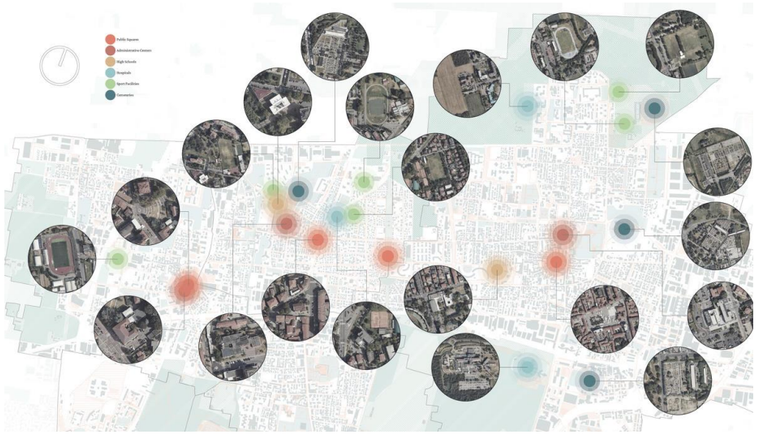
Opportunities

- Continuous public open spaces
- Strenghtening Mobility
- Increased Connectivity
- Equitable NMT access
- Improved quality and vitality

Attractor Mapping

This map visualizes the key civic and functional attractors that organize daily public movement and bridge municipal boundaries across the territory.

The mapping reveals a strong concentration of attractors along the **central east-west urban spine** extending through Cormano, Cusano Milanino, and Cinisello Balsamo.



Activity Mapping

While the attractor map identifies destinations, the activity map reveals how people move between them.

This corridor accommodates overlapping flows associated with **schools, shopping areas, public services, sports facilities, and transit nodes.**

The concentration of multiple attractors along this axis produces a continuous sequence of public activity and reinforces its role as the primary urban spine of the territory.

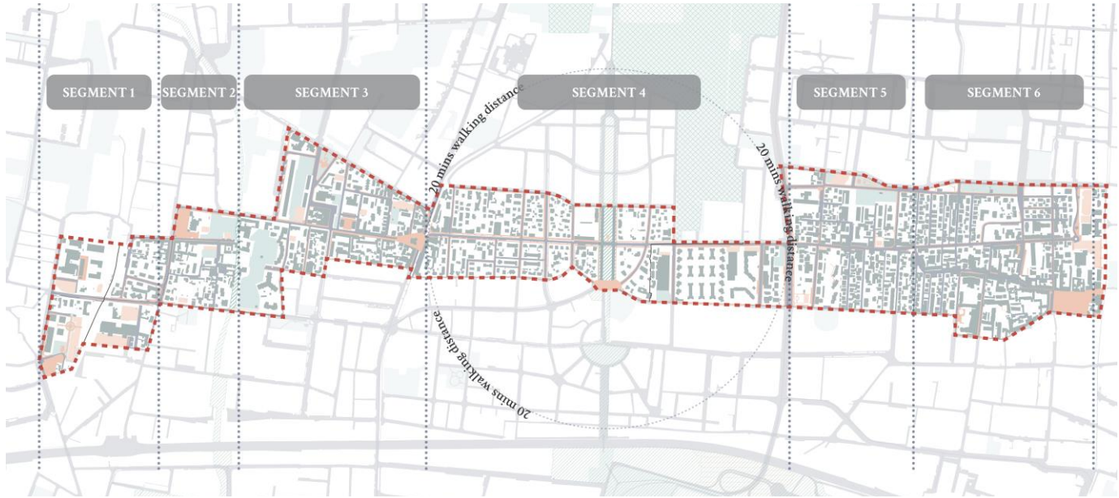


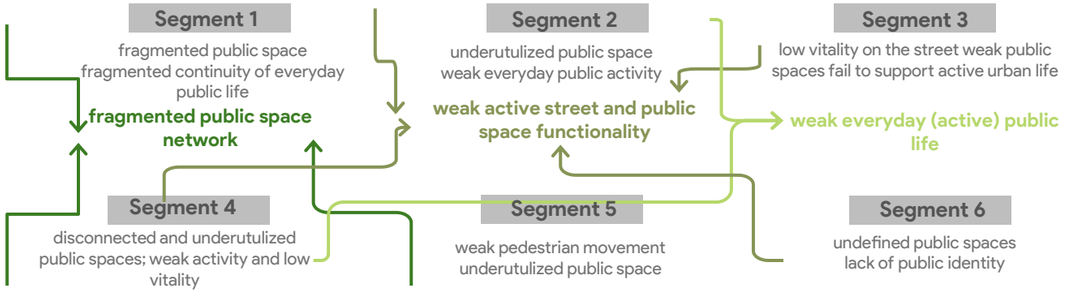
05 TERRITORIAL SCALE TO NEIGHBORHOOD SCALE

The East West Corridor

The east-west corridor runs approximately **3,805m** across the Nord Milano metropolitan fringe, from **Cormano Cusano-Milanino Station in the west** to **Piazza Antonio Gramsci in Cinisello Balsamo in the east.**

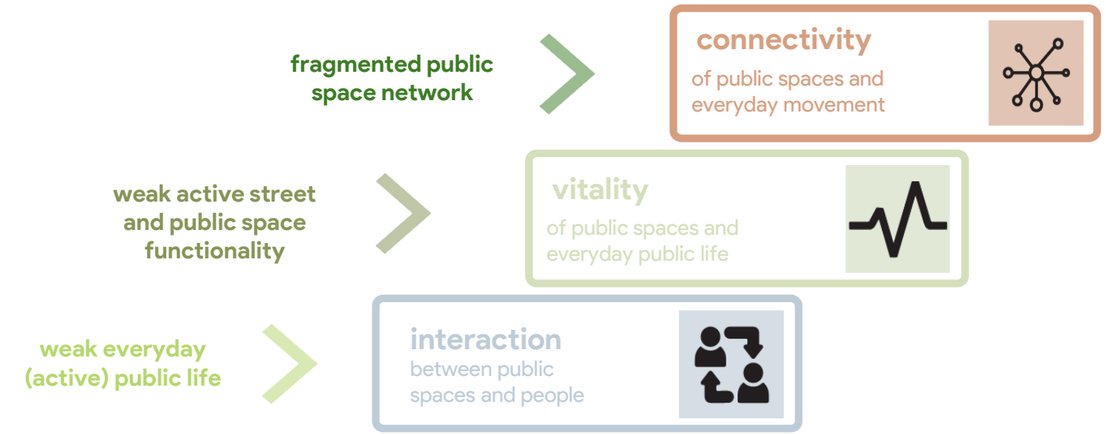
The corridor is organised into six segments, each defined by specific spatial conditions it encounters rather than administrative boundaries.

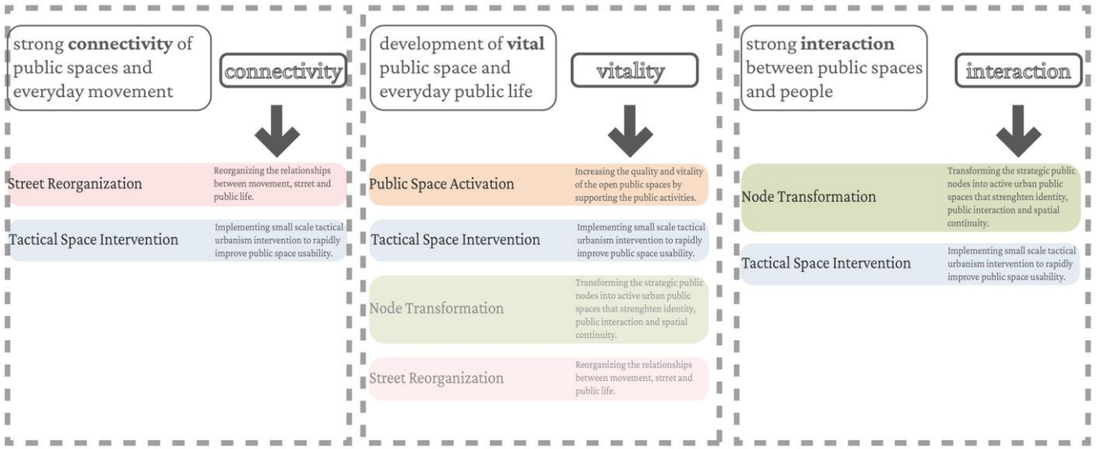


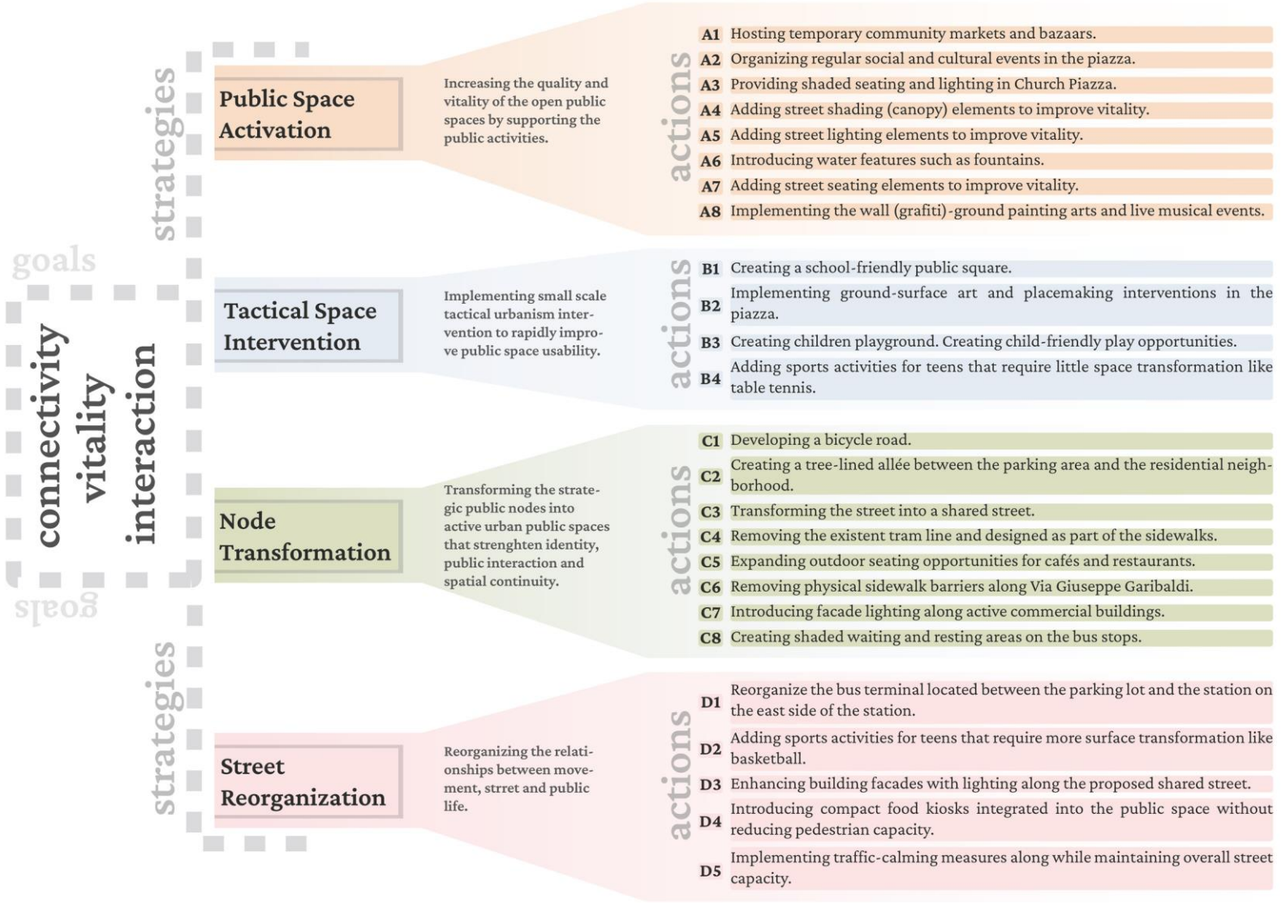


06 STRATEGIC FRAMEWORK

The analysis conducted across all segments revealed a diverse range of spatial, social and functional challenges. The analytical phase reinterpreted key issues into a strategic framework. The initiative viewed these difficulties as signs of a broader problem influencing the creation of publicness in the Northern Milan Metropolitan Area rather than as discrete shortcomings.







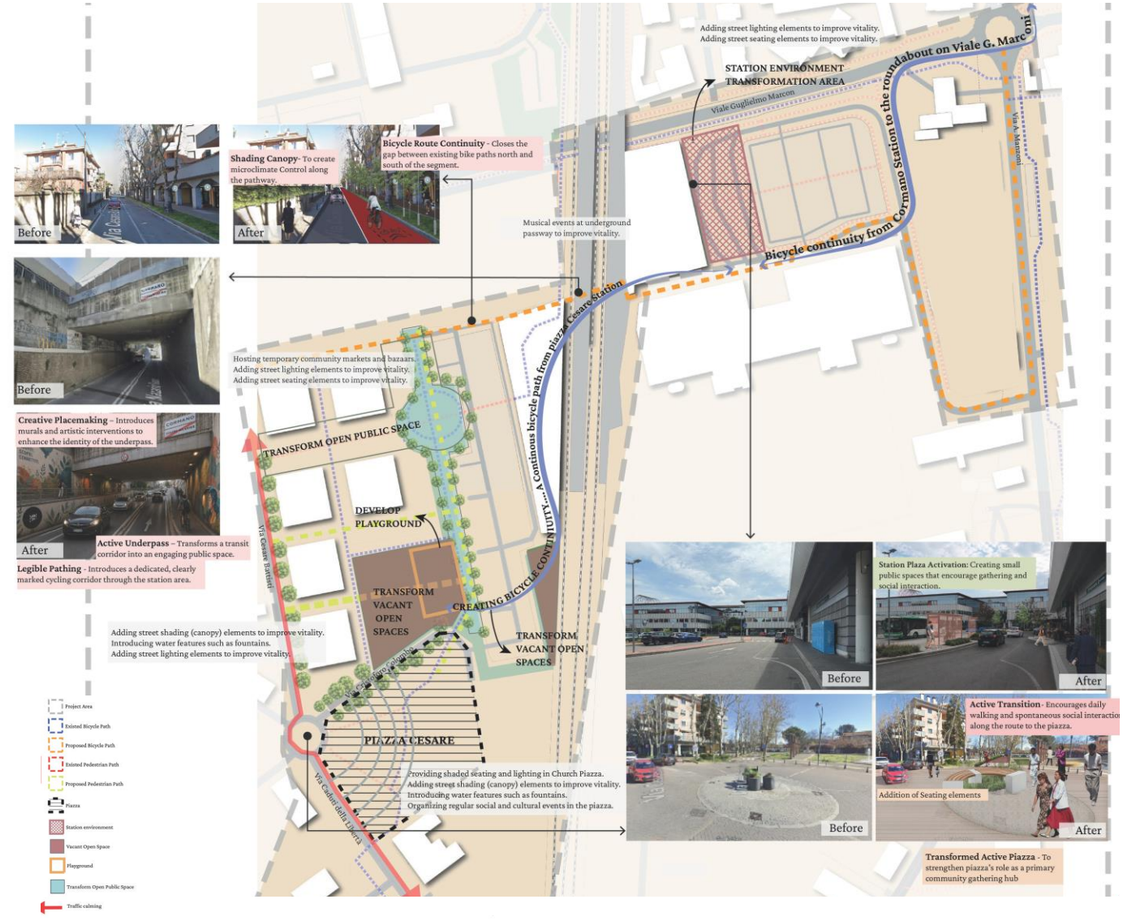
The proposed actions represent the operational dimension of the framework, translating strategic objectives into site-specific interventions.

While the goals establish the desired outcomes and the strategies define the overall approach, the actions provide concrete mechanisms for implementation.

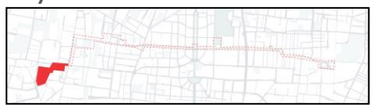
Together, they create a coherent pathway toward enhancing connectivity, vitality, and interaction, ultimately contributing to a more integrated, active, and resilient public space network.

SEGMENT BASED IMPLEMENTATION FRAMEWORK

7.1 SEGMENT 1 : CORMANO STATION



Key Plan





Piazza Cesare



Vacant Space



Allee

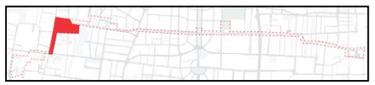


Underpass

7.2 SEGMENT 2: PIAZZA TRENTO E TRIESTE



Key Plan





Piazza Marcellino



Street transformation



School Piazza

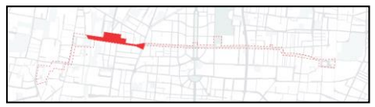


Vacant Space

7.3 SEGMENT 3: VIALE GIACOMO M.



Key Plan

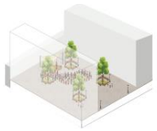




Bus stop Rest Areas



Underutilized Piazza

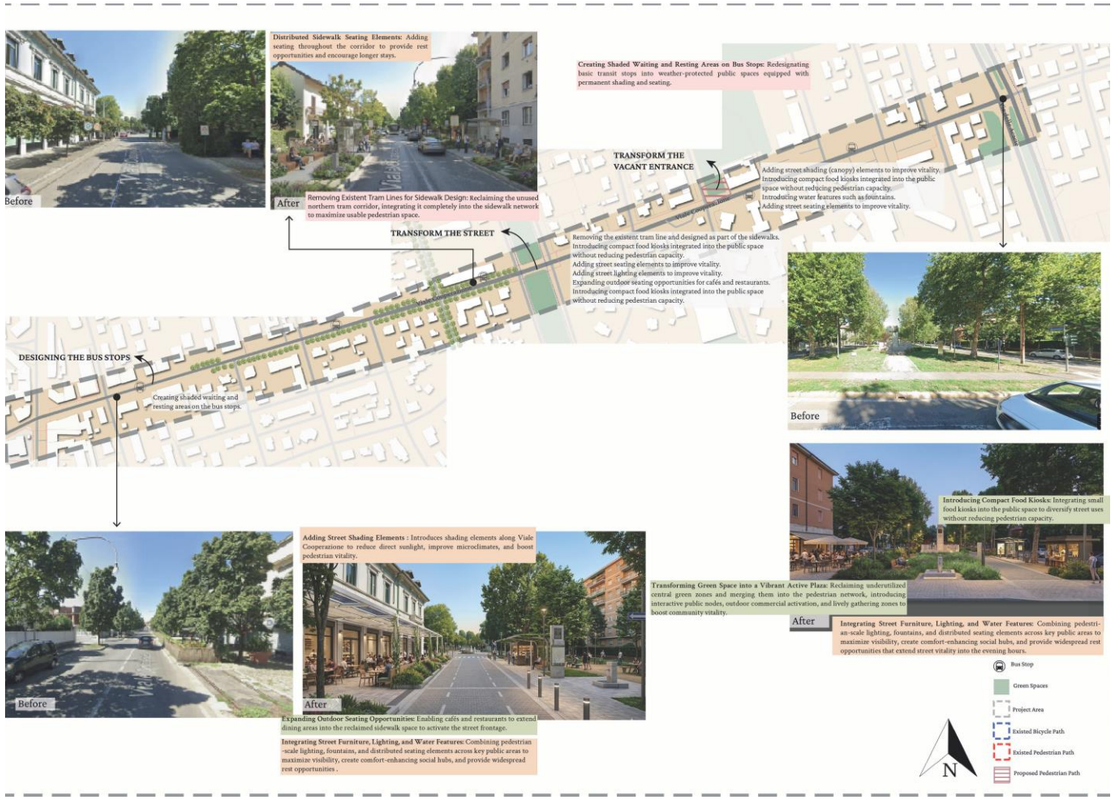


Piazza Actiavation



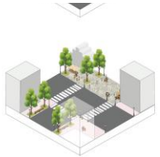
Church Piazza

7.4 SEGMENT 4: CUSANO MILANINO

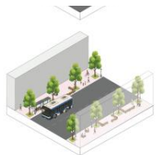


Key Plan





Connection to Seg 3



Bus Stop Rest Areas



Milanino Park

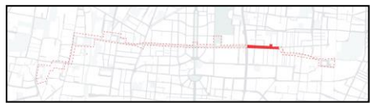


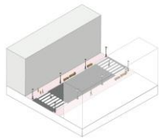
Vacant Piazza

7.5 SEGMENT 5: VIA XXV APRILE

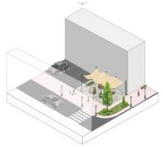


Key Plan

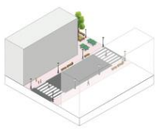




Street Restructure



Outdoor Extension



Street + Pocket Spaces



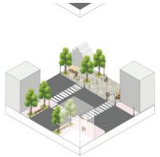
Vacant Space

7.6 SEGMENT 6: GARIBALDI-GRAMSCI

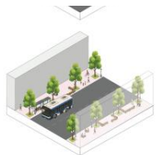


Key Plan





Connection to Seg 3



Bus Stop Rest Areas



Milanino Park



Vacant Piazza

08 HOW PUBLICNESS HAS CHANGED?

The continuous corridor map demonstrates how a sequence of interconnected, context-specific interventions transforms fragmented public spaces into a cohesive public realm, where overlapping strategies collectively strengthen spatial continuity, accessibility, and publicness across Northern Milan.

Public Space Activation
Tactical Space Intervention
Node Transformation
Street Reorganization
Node Transformation
Node Transformation
Tactical Space Intervention
Public Space Activation

Public Space Interventions for Enhanced Urban Vitality
Introducing regular social and cultural events, street canopies, and public seating to create a more comfortable, active, and vibrant piazza that encourages social interaction and everyday use.

Transforming Piazza Aprile through Public Space Interventions
Introducing street canopies to provide shade, improve thermal comfort, and encourage longer stays. Installing public seating to create welcoming spaces for rest, social interaction, and everyday public life.

Removal of the abandoned tram tracks

Street Reorganization and Public Realm Activation
Remove the abandoned tram tracks to reclaim underutilized road space and upgrade bus stops with seating and shading, creating comfortable, pedestrian-friendly public spaces that support both mobility and everyday social activity.

Connectivity

Node Transformation in Piazza Aprile
Organize regular social and cultural events to transform Piazza Aprile into an active community node and strengthen its identity as a vibrant civic destination.

Tactical Public Space Intervention in the School Area
Introducing traffic-calming measures, safer pedestrian crossings, and selective sidewalk extensions along Viale Giacomo Matteotti to create a child-friendly, safe, and comfortable public space that prioritizes walking and everyday community activity.

Continuous Bicycle Connectivity
Establishing a continuous bicycle corridor through the station area by connecting existing northern and southern cycling networks, closing missing links, improving accessibility, and strengthening sustainable multimodal mobility.

Increasing Vitality

Transforming the Cormano Terminal into a Multifunctional Public Node
Transforming Cormano Station from a transit-only interchange into a vibrant, well-connected, and people-oriented mobility hub by enhancing public spaces, improving multimodal accessibility, and activating the station area with community-focused amenities and activities.

Activating Piazza Cesare Scurati as a Vibrant Public Space
Transforming the strategic public node of Piazza Cesare Scurati into active urban public spaces. The piazza's function as a dynamic public place that promotes social interaction and community iden-

Pedestrian-Oriented Public Space Enhancements
Enhance Viale Cooperazione with additional tree canopies, pedestrian-scale lighting, water features, and public seating to create a comfortable, attractive, and vibrant public realm prioritizing the pedestrians.

Removal of the abandoned tram tracks

Increasing Vitality

Enhancing Node Vitality
Transform the node into a vibrant public destination by integrating street canopies, compact food kiosks, water features, and public seating to enhance comfort, vitality, and everyday social activity.

Enhancing Node Vitality
Transforming the node into an active, people-oriented public space through the integration of shaded seating, compact food kiosks, and water features that enhance comfort and urban vitality.

Recreational Space Activation
Transform the vacant green space near the entrance of Parco Grabrio into an active recreational area by introducing a children's playground and small-scale sports facilities to encourage everyday use, physical activity, and social interaction.

Shared Street Transformation
Reorganizing Via Giuseppe Garibaldi as a shared street by widening sidewalks and reallocating street space to prioritize pedestrians while maintaining efficient traffic flow and improving the quality of the public realm.

Public Space Transformation of Piazza Antonio Gramsci
Transforming Piazza Antonio Gramsci into a vibrant, pedestrian-friendly public space by expanding outdoor cafe seating, removing physical barriers, introducing compact food kiosks, and providing public seating to encourage social interaction and everyday public life.

Public Space Activation
Street Reorganization
Tactical Space Intervention
Node Transformation
Influence Area



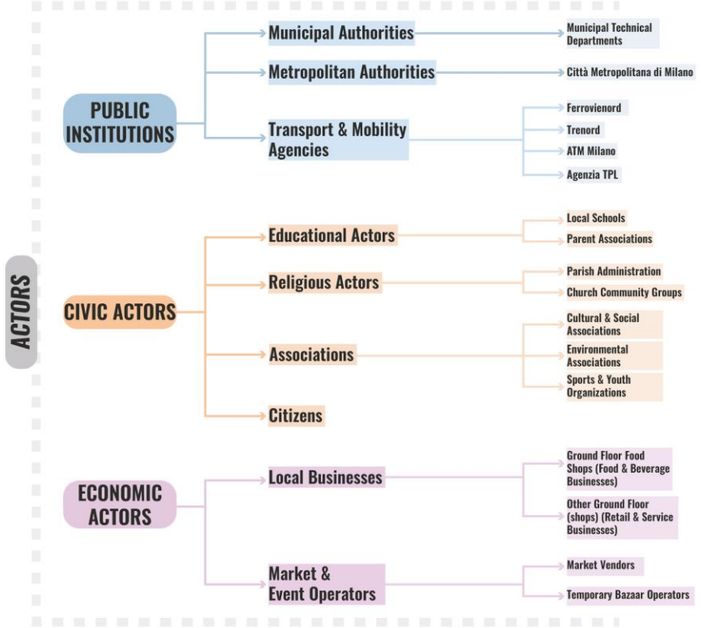
09 INSTITUTIONAL FRAMEWORK

The framework brings together public institutions, civic organizations, and economic actors, recognizing that successful public space transformation depends on collaboration and participation.

GOVERNANCE

COLLABORATION

PARTICIPATION



ACTORS	Public Space Activation	Tactical Interventions	Node Transformation
Municipal Authorities	D, M, I	D, I, M	D, M, I
Metropolitan Authorities			D
Transport & Mobility Agencies			D, I, M
Educational Actors	I, U	I, U	U
Religious Actors	I, U	I, U	U
Associations	I, M, U	I, M, U	I, M, U
Citizens	U	U	U
Local Businesses	M, U	M, U	I, M, U
Market & Event Operators	I, M, U	U	I, M, U

D – Decision Making Actors responsible for approving, regulating, and guiding the intervention.
Question: Who decides?

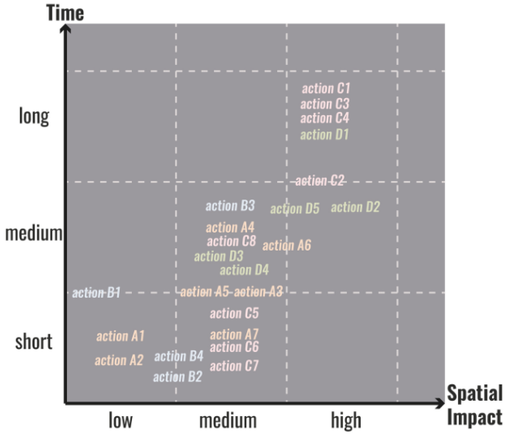
I – Implementation Actors responsible for delivering, constructing, organizing, or carrying out the intervention.
Question: Who makes it happen?

M – Maintenance Actors responsible for the long term management, operation, and maintenance of the intervention.
Question: Who keeps it running?

U – User / Beneficiary Actors who use, experience, or benefit from the intervention in everyday life.
Question: Who benefits from it?

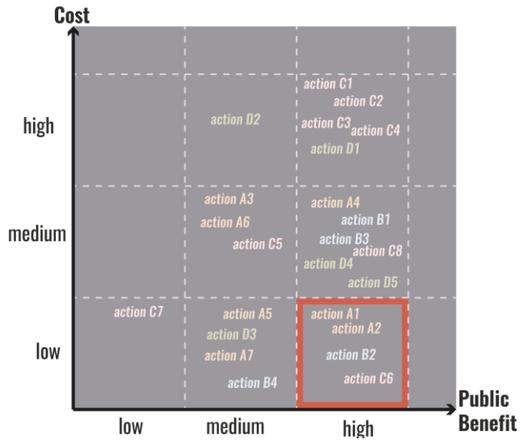
9.1 IMPLEMENTATION STRATEGY

Time vs. Spatial Impact Relation

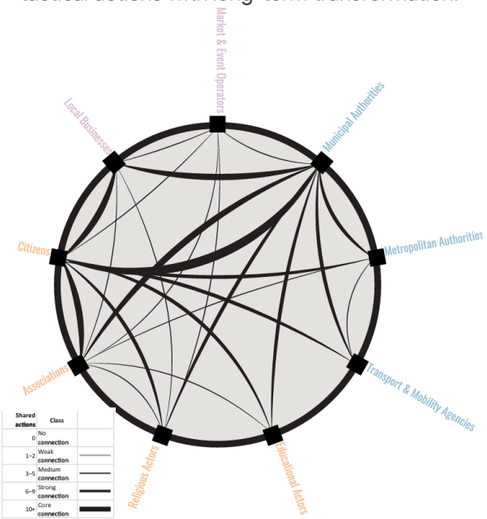


The implementation matrix phases interventions by spatial impact and timeframe, balancing tactical actions with long-term transformation.

Cost and Public Benefit Relation



The cost–benefit matrix prioritizes high-impact, cost-effective interventions, guiding phased investments that maximize public value.



The collaboration network visualizes the interconnected relationships between stakeholders, demonstrating that successful public space transformation depends on coordinated partnerships, shared responsibilities, and continuous collaboration across sectors.

Rather than relying on a hierarchical structure, the framework emphasizes shared responsibilities and cross-sector collaboration, ensuring the long-term implementation, activation, and management of public spaces.

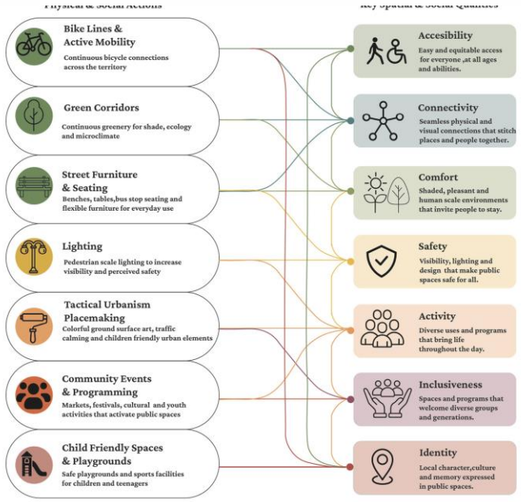
10 CONCLUSION

Reclaiming Publicness In North Milan



Reclaiming publicness requires more than physical interventions; it depends on creating connected, inclusive, and active public spaces that support everyday life.

Together, the proposed actions, publicness tools, and design principles transform fragmented urban spaces into a continuous network that enhances accessibility, comfort, safety, identity, and social interaction.





Publicness in North Milan shifted from fragmented and isolated public spaces to a connected network that supports everyday urban life through accessibility, interaction, and continuity.

11 KEY LEARNINGS

Understanding the City

01 Studying Northern Milan through site visits, spatial observation, and analysis helped in developing a deeper understanding of how cities function beyond planning documents. Observing everyday life, movement patterns, and community interactions revealed how lived experiences shape urban spaces and informed more context-sensitive planning decisions.

Designing for Publicness

02 This project reinforced that public spaces are not defined by their physical form alone, but by how they are accessed, experienced, and governed. Designing for publicness requires integrating spatial planning, mobility, policy, and social inclusion to create places that support everyday urban life.

Small Interventions Can Create Metropolitan Impact

03 The East–West Corridor demonstrated that well-targeted, place-based interventions can generate impacts beyond their immediate context. By reconnecting fragmented neighbourhoods, improving accessibility, and activating underutilized public spaces, local strategies can strengthen metropolitan cohesion and enhance the everyday urban experience.

Policy Design for Implementation

04 The studio reinforced that policy design is a critical planning tool, ensuring that urban interventions are supported by governance frameworks, coordinated decision-making, and long-term implementation rather than remaining conceptual proposals.


SADIYA SHARMIN | PUP24309